

A short conversation between Elizabeth Gurung Tamang and Robert Smith in the ElecEng Staff Room about his Work and Life chart after finishing in 1985.

Fri 03-Jul-2026

ELIZABETH: Thank you for dropping in here before the Elsoc Alumni night event tonight. Please have a seat and have a drink in the kitchen while you're waiting for it to start.

ROBERT: Thank you. I was hoping to catch-up with some staff in their offices. During the undergraduate days, I had a better chance to find the lecturer or tutor in the corridors or the staff room if they were not in their offices.

ELIZABETH: This is the centre where the worker bees return to the hive to refresh. You may know Phil Allen. He's been here a long time.

ROBERT: Yes. He's my main email connection to the School since I've been around it from mid 2016 mixing with the Elsoc executive, their BBQs and some night events. My aim has always been to share what Elsoc is doing with my Alumni friends (the old and the new ones I haven't met yet).

ELIZABETH: Do you know him?

ROBERT: In a way I do. . . Noticed each other at the time with a nod or hello sometimes. I thought he was doing his PhD / Masters in the Dept. of Communications with Pak Chu and Trevor Whitbread. At the time, I was doing my thesis with the help of Tom Millett, the lab manager.

Digression:

Tom worked very closely with Bob Radzyner, my academic thesis supervisor. It was to develop a hardware interface for a new digital signal processor coming to the market from Texas Instruments for the Dept of Main Roads (RTA or Transport NSW now).

Recently, in 2019, I met my industry thesis supervisor Philip Mallon at an ElecEng Alumni night showcasing the solar powered vehicles. We still get along well over email and LinkedIn. He's still teaching and running workshops covering STEM principles at a High School and some public library spaces after working hours and Saturdays. My posts to the Alumni channels are shared to him as well.

Toan Phung was in the High Voltage lab during my undergrad days. Nodded to each other as we passed in the corridors. My interest was Electronics & Communications as I didn't see where I could apply with a High Voltage learning.

Robert Smith

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ELIZABETH: Rob, this is Roy.

ROBERT: G'day Roy. I thought your hair hair turned grey and went to managing the high voltage lab. It's been a long time.

ROY: No, no, not yet... That's the other guy, [Rob: forgot his name. Was it Dave?].

ELIZABETH: How do you know Roy?

ROBERT: I think Julien Epps introduced me when he was head of School. This could've been in the middle of 2021 when the Alumni committee was very active. Julien was keen and proud to show me the Power labs where the big machines are now much smaller for the undergrads. Roy was a Senior Lab Technician that could unlock them for the visitors.

ELIZABETH: I'm glad you caught me. I was having break from a long video call.

ROBERT: No worries. Would you be interested in quickly seeing my one page chart that shows how I've navigated work and life since graduating?

ELIZABETH: Sure thing. I have time before the day ends. It'll help my brain cool down after the conference call.

ROBERT: It was inspired by the chance of explaining what I have done with my life to my friends I haven't seen in many decades at a future Elsoc-Alumni gathering.

It took me a few years to evolve the Excel version. I emailed friends a PDF of it as I found and caught up with them. On the other side of the coin, I thought I could use it to show the Elsoc Executive that work and life rapidly expands once you graduate.

ELIZABETH: Wow! It looks like there's a lot packed on the double A4 page.

ROBERT: It's easy to look up when you see how it's organised. In a few minutes, you can drive around town when you're familiar with the street signs.

ELIZABETH: How is that? Where do I start?

ROBERT: Along the bottom is the time scale. It goes from left to right in years.

b) On the left and right sides you have the titles for the different areas or topics that caught my interest as life developed.

c) The top third of the page is the band of different industries and companies that I have worked in that involved Electronics or Electricity when the political and physical environment changed.

d) The upper middle third is the band for my community involvement.

e) Below that, shows the tinkered Hobbies, the Sport I've played, the Software and Operating systems I've dabbled with and the courses I've completed and applied.

f) The band across the bottom shows where I've lived (towns & councils) and the mutual human relationships along the way.

g) Now for the solid vertical lines:

- _i) Left third was my time in Sydney.
- _ii) Middle was in Albury / Wodonga.
- _iii) The Right third is the Newcastle / Maitland area.

I'm still in touch with a few friends from each town over the mobile, email, facebook and physical coffee catch-ups.

h) For the other vertical lines with letters, they were added in to help the undergraduates see that life still goes on during the:

- _i) Recession times (R),
- _ii) Global Financial Crisis times (G),
- _iii) Covid restrictions (V) and
- _iv) current Oil Crisis in the Middle East (O).

If you're curious, the active links to these times are on the bottom left of the page.

You now have sign posts on the highway to drive around and search for answers to your questions and make the story. That's the 10% of it. The other 90% is discovery and connection. Many stop here as it involves reading, thinking and comprehending the parts.

ELIZABETH: It all makes sense.

ROBERT: Like with any circuit or system diagram, once you identify the parts and see how they're associated, you have a map that can help you understand the environment better to work with it. The time consuming thing is working out what each part is supposed to do. The synchronicity of things helps here too. If not now, then at the right time.

ELIZABETH: Now, I see how you have had a good work-life balance over the years.

ROBERT: When I first met Jinhong in person (mid 2024) after many emails welcoming him as the new head of School after Julien Epps, I showed him my work-life navigation chart so he could see my association with ElecEng. Little explanation was needed for the good questions and excitement that followed.

I didn't have to explain much of it to Julien Epps when he saw it and Elsoc-Industry night and commented, "It's a Gannt Chart". He said no more while his eyeballs were pressing on the page. I said, "I based it on the timing diagram of different signals to and from a microprocessor with the outside world." He understood as his thesis supervisor was Bob Radzyner as well. Similar 'upbringing' but a decade apart.

Toan Phung and Phil Allen, had a quiet time too when the eyes and the brain were co-ordinating what they saw on the chart for the first time. Very little explanation needed.

Even some of the recent undergradates that dared to look at it for more than 30 seconds at the latest Elsoc-Industry night needed little or no explanation. Some questions were:

- _i) "What kind of heavy metal music do you like?"
- _ii) "How did you get a job in a new town when you didn't know anyone?"
- _iii) "What did you do in the Military there?"
- _iv) "Why did you stop your squash?"
- _v) "What was it like living in Albury?"

ELIZABETH: Thank you for sharing that chart and your time.

ROBERT: Feel free to ask or share anything over email or LinkedIn. I understand my replies may be 'out-of-date' but sometimes the conversation with another is the value you get from it.

Next step: How do I fit in the start of commercial internet, the first email (Mar 1993) and the search engines like Google (1998)?

ElecEng's Unix system had email and user accounts in the early 1980's. 15 years was a long time to wait and be effective in the commercial world. Some new graduates may feel the same.

By the way, the latest single page launched from my evolving EEx site is:
PDF: [Navigation Cycles](#) (landscape).

Rob Smith
Tues 6:55 AM (typed-up)
7 Jul 2026
<https://eeexplorer.info/>

Robert Smith
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